wood specimens from sites in the upper Gangetic plains, suggest this.[8] These forests did not, however, deter either travel or trade.

A grand arc of communication existed across this northern axis, humming with people and products, and was called the Uttarapatha (northern road). Originating in the regions beyond Taxila and sweeping across the Indus and Gangetic plains, the Uttarapatha went much beyond Pataliputra, to the port town of Tamralipti on the eastern coast.[9] Traders, pedlars, caravan leaders, religious men, and princes commonly figure as travellers on this route; and, as we saw, Megasthenes too had journeyed over this stretch. Much before him, residents of Magadha are known to have travelled the long way to Taxila. In a story set in the time of the Buddha, a resident of the Magadhan capital Rajagriha, Jivaka by name, went to train under a renowned physician at Taxila,[10] returning to his home town after a studentship that lasted as long as seven years.

While texts make the Uttarapatha visible through such journeys, archaeological sites have yielded raw materials that were conveyed along the same route. Beyond Taxila, from Afghanistan, lapis lazuli, for instance, appears to have been in demand in the cities across this axis, from Rairh in Rajasthan to Sravasti and Rajghat in the middle Gangetic plains.[11] Many other exotic stones and metals, from tin to silver, came into northern India from Afghanistan. For Bindusara this was an important reason for ensuring peace in Taxila and friendship with its citizens. The settlement had become vital as a hub for traders and merchants from Central Asia on their journey into the heartland of Gangetic India.

Some decades before Ashoka’s putative journey Chandragupta had pacified the Punjab and incorporated it into his empire, this being necessary to consolidate Magadhan supremacy further up towards the Hindukush mountains. If Taxila, the premier city of this frontier region of the Mauryan empire, was restive, the impact on overall stability within the geopolitical orbit could be disastrous.[12] Quelling turbulence there was additionally